

Yu Cai

I appreciate the opportunity to provide input on the development of an AI Action Plan. As a researcher in computing, AI, and cybersecurity, I would like to emphasize the critical role of federal funding for fundamental scientific research in ensuring the continued advancement and responsible development of AI technologies. One of the most concerning trends this year has been the erosion of federal support for fundamental research, particularly within the NSF. AI research does not occur in isolation; it relies on a strong foundation of discoveries from mathematics, physics, cognitive science, cybersecurity, and computer systems research. Reductions in funding for NSF and other federal research agencies jeopardize this ecosystem, limiting the potential for breakthrough innovations and hindering the United States' ability to maintain global leadership in AI. AI research does not exist in a vacuum. Its success depends on interdisciplinary collaboration with fields such as neuroscience, linguistics, material sciences, and cybersecurity, among many others. Without sustained investment in these interconnected disciplines, AI research will face significant barriers in areas such as explainability, robustness, and security. Moreover, policy discussions on AI funding should not be confined solely to AI-specific initiatives but should also include substantial investments in basic sciences, high-performance computing, and research infrastructure. AI models are increasingly reliant on advancements in quantum computing, semiconductor technology, and biological computing, all of which require strong government-backed research support. If the U.S. government is serious about maintaining AI leadership, it must reverse the trend of funding cuts for fundamental research and commit to a comprehensive, long-term AI research strategy that strengthens investments across multiple scientific domains. This approach should include: Increased NSF funding to support foundational AI and interdisciplinary research. Sustained support for high-risk, high-reward research that industry alone is unlikely to fund. Enhancing collaboration between academia, government, and industry while ensuring open access to critical AI research findings. Investment in AI infrastructure, including secure and ethical data-sharing platforms to facilitate cutting-edge research. Conclusion The success of AI research and its responsible deployment depend on broad-based scientific investment and an interdisciplinary approach. The U.S. government must prioritize funding for basic research through NSF and other agencies rather than cutting critical support for the broader scientific community. Without this commitment, the long-term sustainability and competitiveness of AI research in the United States will be at serious risk. I appreciate the opportunity to contribute to this discussion and strongly urge policymakers to reaffirm their commitment to federal funding for fundamental research as a cornerstone of the national AI strategy.